

Session 8: Adultery and Lust

Key Takeaways

- Jesus explains that adultery and lust come from a common source. Just because we don't commit adultery doesn't mean we are free from the root problem.
- Jesus directly confronts the public social dynamic of men staring at women in order to stir up desire, emphasizing that in his Kingdom, women are to be safe.
- The eye and the hand are used together as a common Hebrew Bible idiom to represent both our focus and what we do in response to our ingrained patterns of thinking.
- By identifying the problem as one of the heart, Jesus makes it clear that he's not commanding self-mutilation when he speaks of tearing out your eye or cutting off your hand. Instead, he's using an arresting image to make a clear point: At all costs, don't let a habit of the mind or body prevent you from doing what is clearly best for yourself and others.

Case Study 2: Adultery & Lust

- a 27 You have heard that **it was said**,
b "You shall not **commit adultery**";

- a' 28 **and I say** to you that
b' everyone who **goes on looking** at a woman in order to cultivate lust for her,
he has already **committed adultery** with her in **his heart**.

- a 29 If your **right eye** **causes your downfall**,
b tear it out and **throw** it from you;

- a' for it is better for you to lose **one of your body-parts**,
b' than for **your whole body** to be **thrown** into **gehenna**.

- a 30 If your **right hand** **causes your downfall**,
b cut it off and **throw** it from you;

- a' for it is better for you to lose **one of your body-parts**,
b' than for **your whole body** to **go off** into **gehenna**.

Jesus quotes the seventh of the Ten Commandments. He does not offer an antithesis (“but I say adultery is fine”), but neither does he simply comment on adultery as such. He delves deeper, revealing the subterranean character issues at work “in the heart.” Jesus’ language has several nuances that are often missed on a first reading.

- “goes on looking” (ὁ βλέπων γυναιῖκα, present tense participle): The action is on-going, sustained, and prolonged. He is addressing “the stare,” where one’s purpose is to use another for personal pleasure and satisfaction.
- “in order to lust after her” (πρὸς τὸ ἐπιθυμῆσαι αὐτήν, infinitive purpose clause)
 - Jesus is not referring to the casual look, where someone notices a sexually attractive person. He is referring to the stare that is intentionally prolonged in order to form an image in one’s mind and create a fantasy.
 - This is often translated as an adverb, “lustfully” (NIV), “with lust” (NASB, NRSV). This is not helpful, as it can refer to the unintentional desires that are activated. Jesus uses an expression of purpose, “with intent to lust” (ESV) or “in order to lust” (KJV). This emphasis should be preserved in translation if we want to understand him.

In parallel with the previous teaching about how murder begins with angry contempt, so also adultery begins with the lust-filled stare. Jesus locates adultery at the level of distorted desire, and the choice to continue fueling that desire through the stare. The stare denigrates the dignity and value of the other, treating them as a sub-human, passive object that exists for my pleasure and purposes. It is the ultimate form of dehumanization.

“We should not make the bowstring too taut here, as if anyone who is tempted to look with lust is eternally damned for it. ... ‘I cannot keep a bird from flying over my head. But I can certainly keep it from nesting in my hair or from biting my nose off.’”

Luther, Martin (2017). [Commentary on the Sermon on the Mount](#). Lexham Press.

The Right Eye / Right Hand

“If your right hand/eye ...”: Because the majority of people are right-handed, it became a common saying, assuming that the right hand (or whichever is used most) is the most useful. The point is to highlight the extreme nature of the action. Even what is most useful is to be sacrificed when one’s life is at stake.

Jesus believes that distorted sexual desire is a matter of serious consequence, which is why he uses the phrase “cause to stumble” (Greek: *skandalizomai*). The kind of “fall” Jesus has in mind is not a minor slip, but a crash to the ground.

He’s talking about sexual desire taking over your life and shipwrecking your ability to make wise choices. Sin is the inward turn and the destruction of outward living and healthy relationships.

Jesus is not denigrating sex or sexual desire. There’s an entire book of his Bible dedicated to the celebration of love and sexual desire (Song of Songs). What Jesus addresses here is distorted desire that is aimed at

someone you don't love or have any commitment to. Sexual desire apart from covenantal commitment allows people to use each other.

Jesus is not suppressing sexuality, but telling us that some things matter more than gratifying our sexual desires, like the dignity of people who are made as the image of God.

Self-Mutilation

Jesus clearly isn't commanding self-mutilation; rather, he's using an arresting image to make a clear point: At all costs, don't let a habit of the mind and body prevent you from doing what is clearly best for yourself and others.

The command is not to be taken literally, as if Jesus thinks that amputation can curb sexual passion. Not to mention the fact that he doesn't mention the body part that, for men, would be the first thing to amputate in order to solve the problem. The body is not the problem. That is way too simplistic. The problem is not with the body itself, but "in the heart," as he said in [Matthew 5:28](#).

Jesus' point is to take decisive action against that habit, thing, or person that, though pleasurable and perhaps seemingly indispensable for living, is in fact ruining our lives (see Bruner). Life in the Kingdom will require some degree of loss, of denial, of withdrawing from things that seem fine or even good.

Notice that Jesus focuses on men. Not that women aren't included, but Jesus puts extra emphasis on this teaching aimed at men. Jesus wants to emphasize that in his Kingdom, women are to be safe.

Reflection Question

What are the implications of Jesus' teaching to tear out your eye or cut off your hand if they cause you to stumble?